

THE SYSTEM AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL

An overall reading of the contradictions of the contemporary world

Foreword

The contemporary world can be described through economic, demographic, environmental, technological and political data. We can measure growth, productivity, debt, poverty, concentration of wealth, consumption of resources, demographic change, trust in institutions and climate transformation.

But an exclusively systemic reading risks losing sight of the subject who lives inside these processes: the individual.

A person does not experience GDP, productivity or market capitalisation. A person experiences the possibility of working, having a home, receiving care, studying, having relationships, forming a family, saving, having time and imagining a future.

The central question therefore becomes the relationship between what the system produces and what it concretely allows people to live.

My interpretation starts from here: the problem of the present is not necessarily that the system produces too little. It could be, on the contrary, that it produces enormously without proportionately transforming this wealth into security, freedom, time, opportunity and capacity to choose for the individual.

The crisis of capitalism can then be read not as its imminent disappearance, but as a progressive loss of coherence between production, distribution, power, responsibility and legitimacy.

I. The individual inside the system

1. The system seen from below

From the individual's point of view, the economy can be reduced to a concrete chain:

time → work → income → home → consumption → savings → health →
relationships → security → future.

It is through this chain that the great economic phenomena are perceived.

Growth becomes the cost of housing.

Monetary policy becomes the cost of credit.

Demographic transformation becomes caring for one's parents or the difficulty of having children.

The energy crisis becomes the cost of energy.

Climate change becomes the cost of food, of insurance or of the safety of the territory.

This is why a society can be richer overall and, at the same time, leave many individuals with a growing difficulty in building autonomy.

It does not necessarily mean that the general material condition is worse than in the past. It means that aggregate growth does not automatically guarantee a proportional growth in individual possibilities.

2. The promise

Modern capitalism has built part of its legitimacy around an implicit promise: those who work, educate themselves, save and take on responsibility should be able to improve their condition progressively.

But when the relationship between effort and result becomes less and less predictable, the question no longer concerns poverty alone.

It concerns the perception of a fracture between what is asked of the individual and what the system gives back.

A person can do what the system asks and still discover that home, security, family, health or time depend on conditions over which that person has limited control.

Thus the first contradiction arises:

one can be responsible for one's own choices without really being master of the conditions within which those choices produce their effects.

II. The broken promise

3. Productivity and life

Productivity can increase enormously without its benefit being automatically transformed into greater security or freedom.

The same increase in productivity can become:

- wages;
- profit;
- investment;
- lower prices;
- public service;
- shorter working hours;
- greater consumption;
- greater accumulation.

There is no automatic distribution of technological progress.

This is why more technology, more productivity and more wealth can coexist with precariousness, concentration and individual insecurity.

The question is therefore not whether technology is good or bad.

It is who controls the benefit it produces and in what form that benefit returns to society.

4. Productivity, labour and demand

Capital continually seeks greater productivity.

Technology makes it possible to produce more with less labour.

But labour is also an essential component of the income that sustains demand.

In simplified form:

capital → technology → productivity → less labour needed

but also:

labour → income → consumption → demand → revenue → investment.

The system must therefore maintain a relationship between productivity and distribution.

When a growing share of the value produced separates from the income distributed to labour, demand has to be sustained by other means: consumption by the holders of capital, public spending, exports, redistribution, credit or financial expansion.

Some of them may work.

But they may also simply shift the problem forward in time.

5. The home as an example

The home makes the contradiction evident.

It is at once a fundamental need, an economic good, an asset, an investment and financial collateral.

For those who own capital it can represent security and wealth. For those who lack it, it can become a barrier to entry into stability.

The problem therefore cannot be reduced to individual responsibility alone.

When a person has to work more and more to gain access to a fundamental good whose price also depends on credit, investment, availability of land and market structure, a precise contradiction emerges:

the system can ask the individual for greater efficiency while making the individual's autonomy ever more dependent on variables the individual does not control.

III. Power, wealth and decision-making capacity

6. Wealth is also capacity

Inequality does not concern only the quantity of goods owned.

Wealth allows one to wait, take risks, withstand crises, invest, protect oneself and choose.

Those who have capital generally have a different room for manoeuvre from those who have only their own labour.

This is why a great economic concentration also produces an asymmetric distribution of possibilities.

Economic differences are not automatically unjust.

They become more problematic when they turn into differences in the capacity to determine the future.

Inequality then becomes a difference in the capacity to be autonomous.

The difference is not only:

how much you own.

It is:

how much you can afford to decide.

And how far you can modify the conditions within which others, too, have to live.

7. When economic capacity becomes capacity to influence

Democracy formally grants citizens a political voice; the market, by contrast, distributes economic capacity according to property, income and capital.

The two logics can coexist, but they can also come into tension.

The problem becomes particularly evident when people perceive that they have little capacity to influence the decisions that concern their own lives.

The question of inequality then also becomes a question of agency, that is, of the effective capacity to take part in determining the conditions of one's own existence.

And here the decisive problem emerges:

who decides, who benefits, who pays and who can correct the decision?

When these four positions grow too far apart, economic inequality also becomes a question of legitimacy.

8. The distance between decision and consequence

An economic decision can produce an immediate benefit and costs distributed over time or space.

A firm can gain efficiency while a territory faces changes in employment.

An investment can produce a return while others bear environmental costs.

A policy can produce benefits in the present by transferring obligations to the future.

The point is not to assign individual blame automatically.

It is to recognise a structural problem:

when the capacity to decide grows faster than the responsibility towards those who will suffer the consequences, the system produces an asymmetry of power.

This is perhaps the deepest form of systemic injustice: living inside decisions that one did not help to make and that one does not have the capacity to correct.

IV. Individual responsibility inside systemic problems

9. Responsibility is individualised

The individual is asked to get an education, keep up to date, be competitive, save, work, be flexible, look after their own health and prepare for change.

But the individual does not determine housing prices, interest rates, the economic cycle, the tax structure, the labour market, the distribution of capital, the cost of energy, geopolitics or technological evolution.

From this a possible asymmetry arises:

the consequences are individualised while many of the causes are systemic.

At that point the question becomes inevitable:

how far can the individual be held responsible for results that are also determined by variables they do not control?

This does not eliminate personal responsibility.

It does, however, impose a condition of justice:

responsibility should be proportionate to the effective capacity to influence the causes.

V. When individual rationality produces collective irrationality

10. The paradox

One of the deepest contradictions of complex systems is that millions of rational decisions can produce a result that no one chose.

A person may decide to have fewer children because the cost of living is too high. It is an understandable choice.

Many people may make the same choice. The birth rate falls, the population ages, the pressure on care and pension systems increases, and the next generation may find itself in even more difficult conditions.

The same pattern can appear in housing, in automation, in saving, in the consumption of resources or in indebtedness.

The firm cuts costs because it has to compete.

The worker accepts worse conditions because they have to keep their income.

The investor seeks a return because that is what the system requires of them.

The consumer seeks the lowest price because they have to protect their income.

This is a fundamental contradiction:

a system can transform individual rationality into collective irrationality.

The problem, therefore, is not only to correct people's behaviour.

It is to build institutions capable of coordinating individual interests towards collectively sustainable results.

VI. The consumption of the future

11. Debt

Debt is an instrument that makes it possible to bring forward future economic capacity.

It is not negative in itself: it can finance investment, infrastructure and productive activities.

It becomes problematic when a growing share of future income has to be used to sustain obligations already created.

The system then becomes ever more dependent on its own future capacity to produce growth, income and returns.

Debt thus becomes not only a financial instrument, but a relationship with the future.

12. Growth and limits

Modern growth has been sustained by industrialisation, urbanisation, population increase, energy consumption, infrastructure, new markets and the exploitation of resources.

Today many of these margins are harder to widen.

The population is ageing, infrastructure has to be maintained, the energy transition requires investment, the climate generates new costs and material resources remain finite.

Growth is not necessarily impossible.

It is, however, ever more dependent on productivity, innovation, efficiency and the capacity to use less matter and energy to obtain greater utility.

The fundamental question therefore changes:

not how much we can produce, but how much we can produce without consuming the conditions of future production.

13. A system that can consume its own conditions of existence

An economy does not use financial capital alone.

It also uses:

natural resources, health, time, infrastructure, trust, human capital, social capital, institutional capacity and the environment.

If it consumes these resources faster than it manages to replenish them, it can increase production in the short term while at the same time reducing its own future capacity.

Just as debt uses future income, environmental degradation uses future ecological capacity.

Underinvestment means using future infrastructure.

Precarisation means consuming human capital.

Low cohesion means consuming social capital.

In this perspective one of the deepest contradictions emerges:

the present can be financed by transferring costs onto the future.

The question therefore also becomes a distributive one:

who benefits today and who bears the cost tomorrow?

VII. The crisis of legitimacy

14. When the system no longer appears correctable

A system can be unequal, inefficient and even produce crises without immediately losing legitimacy.

The fracture grows deeper when the conviction spreads that the ordinary instruments are no longer sufficient to correct it.

If the individual thinks:

"I can study, work, save and behave responsibly, but the fundamental conditions of my life are decided elsewhere",

a loss of agency is produced.

When this perception becomes widespread, the question is no longer only economic.

It becomes institutional.

15. From economic crisis to the moral question

At this point the questions change.

It is not enough to ask:

how much does the system produce?

One must ask:

how does it distribute what it produces?

who decides?

who bears the consequences?

how much control does the individual really have over their own life?

how legitimate is it to transfer costs to future generations?

why should the increase in productivity necessarily translate into greater production and not also into more human time?

Data can describe these conditions.

But they cannot establish by themselves what is just.

My normative interpretation is that a system becomes progressively fragile when it demands responsibility from individuals without guaranteeing them a proportionate capacity to influence the fundamental conditions of their own existence.

And it is here that the critique of the present becomes a question about the future.

VIII. Beyond capitalism: building the alternative

16. Correcting the effects is not enough

If the contradictions described were only occasional errors, it would be sufficient to correct them.

But if they derive from the very way in which property, labour, production, value, accumulation and power are organised, redistribution alone cannot be the definitive answer.

Income can be redistributed without changing the ownership of the means of production.

Pollution can be taxed without changing the general criterion that makes it profitable to produce.

Workers can be protected while labour is kept as a commodity.

Public services can be financed while fundamental goods are left inside a logic that depends predominantly on income.

Capital can be regulated without changing the structural necessity of its valorisation.

Redistribution acts on the result.

Systemic change must act on the conditions that produce that result.

17. Changing the relationship between value and need

A different society must start from a fundamental distinction:

what has a price does not necessarily coincide with what has value, and what has economic value does not necessarily coincide with what is necessary.

Production must start from real need, distribution from availability and necessity, organisation from the contribution actually required.

18. From labour as a commodity to contribution

If survival does not depend on selling one's labour, necessary labour takes on a different meaning.

The question is not simply to work less.

It is to decide what must be produced, how much it is necessary to produce and how much human time is really necessary to do so.

If productivity increases, the first dividend should also be able to be time.

Technology could therefore become not only an instrument for producing more, but an instrument for giving life back to human time.

19. From ownership of the fundamental means to common custody

Not all goods have the same nature.

Personal objects, the home one lives in and individual tools can belong to the personal sphere.

Land, water, energy sources, essential infrastructure, means of production, knowledge, networks and technological nodes, by contrast, have a different character: control over them determines the material possibilities of others.

The principle is not:

everything belongs to everyone.

It is:

what determines the fundamental conditions of life must not be able to become an unlimited private power over others.

20. From the market as a principle to the market as an instrument

Going beyond capitalism does not necessarily mean eliminating every form of exchange.

It means taking away from the market the role of universal criterion.

For essential goods the criterion becomes need.

For common resources, sustainability.

For technical functions, competence.

For collective decisions, deliberation.

For production, the real requirement.

The economic problem does not disappear.

It is relocated.

21. From money to knowledge of the real cost

Abolishing money as a universal measure does not mean giving up accounting.

A complex society must know how much it costs to produce, transport, maintain and repair a good.

But cost and price are not the same thing.

The problem therefore becomes that of building instruments capable of making visible time, matter, energy, logistics, maintenance and consumption of resources, without transforming this measurement into a new form of accumulation.

22. From concentrated power to distributed power

Changing ownership without changing power would produce a new concentration.

Power must not become a permanent position.

It must be a temporary, competent, controllable and reversible function.

The fundamental difference is between exercising a function and possessing power.

23. Technology as an instrument, not as a sovereign

The same distinction applies to artificial intelligence.

AI can collect data, detect needs, propose solutions and optimise systems too complex to be managed manually.

But it must not become the subject of the decision.

Technology must therefore increase the human capacity to understand and decide, not replace it.

24. From growth to sufficiency

Finally, the ecological question requires us to change the criterion of progress.

On a finite planet the quantitative increase of material production cannot be taken indefinitely as the universal measure of success.

Sufficiency does not mean poverty.

It means distinguishing:

- need from accumulation;

- quality from quantity;

- durability from consumption;

- repair from replacement;

- well-being from possession.

25. The individual remains the centre

The opposite risk would be to replace economic individualism with a collectivity that absorbs the person.

That is not the direction.

The alternative must start from the individual.

The limit placed on power over fundamental goods is therefore joined by a second principle:

no one must be deprived of necessary goods because they do not own enough.

Freedom does not consist only in being able to choose.

It also consists in having the minimum material conditions to be able to choose in reality.

Conclusion — Building what comes after

At this point the path of the analysis can be put back together.

We start from the individual.

We observe that the individual's life depends more and more on processes they do not control.

We see that the wealth produced does not automatically turn into autonomy.

We observe that economic power can become the capacity to influence the conditions of others.

We recognise that individual responsibility can be disproportionate to real control.

We understand that millions of rational behaviours can produce collectively irrational results.

We see that productivity, capital, debt, growth and consumption of resources are linked.

And finally the fundamental problem emerges: a system cannot be judged only by the quantity of wealth it produces, but also by the conditions of life, freedom and future that it leaves behind.

From this perspective, the conclusion to which this analysis leads is that capitalism must no longer be the dominant principle of social organisation.

Not simply because it is considered morally unsatisfactory, but because it is no longer capable of reconciling production, freedom, justice, sustainability and responsibility.

Capitalism must end.

But this sentence acquires meaning only if one understands what comes after.

If the fundamental structures remain the same, the problem may simply reappear in another form.

Truly going beyond it requires changing the relationship between person and system, need and production, labour and survival, property and power, technology and decision, present and future.

There does not exist today a complete, verified and universally applicable alternative system capable of replacing capitalism in its entirety.

There are partial experiences: cooperatives, mutualism, commons, universal services, public ownership, social economies, energy communities, participatory instruments, open technologies and many other forms.

But none of them constitutes on its own a complete answer to the contradictions examined.

This is why the alternative cannot be presented as a ready-made formula.

It must be built.

And it is here that the Constitution of the Circles takes on its meaning.

Not as a system already proven.

Not as a perfect model.

Not as a dogma.

But as the first concrete architecture of an alternative that does not yet fully exist.

It is a matter of building a system in which individual and collectivity cease to be opposed because the freedom of the one becomes materially possible through the responsibility of the other.

The alternative, however, cannot be considered finished even once it has been written.

It will have to be tested.

It will have to fail at certain points.

It will have to be corrected.

Because the greatest risk would be to replace a system that claims to be inevitable with another that claims to be perfect.

And this is perhaps the point at which the analysis of the present finally becomes a project.

We do not yet know what the society to come will be in its definitive form.

But we do know which contradictions we can no longer ignore.

The end of capitalism is not the point of arrival.

It is the point at which the hardest work begins.

Building what comes after.

And perhaps this is the most coherent conclusion I can give to the whole analysis:

we are not obliged to regard the system we have inherited as inevitable.

But if we want to go beyond it, we cannot limit ourselves to rejecting it.

We must become capable of building another way of living.